



OFF-SIDE

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A FORTRESS TESTED BY ITS OWN FOUNDATIONS

After New Zealand and South Africa **exposed the very home conditions** India thought it controlled, even that old certainty feels less secure.

India's cricketing identity has long rested on the shoulders of spin. Long before analytics and matchups entered dressing rooms, the quartet of Bishan Singh Bedi, Bhagwat Chandrasekhar, Erapalli Prasanna and S. Venkataraghavan shaped how India utilised home advantage. Between them, they claimed 468 Test wickets in India, delivering 14 wins across 51 home Tests in which at least one featured. Their craft defined a philosophy, creating a template for how India would win in its own conditions.

When India returned battered from Australia and South Africa in the early 1990s, Mohammad Azharuddin and Ajit Wadekar went back to that blueprint. A young Anil Kumble, Venkatapathy Raju and Rajesh Chauhan became the new axis of control as India dismantled Graham Gooch's England in 1992-93. India swept the series 3-0, with the trio taking 46 wickets.

Even as India developed a generation of dependable fast bowlers — Javagal Srinath, Venkatesh Prasad, Zaheer Khan, Ishant Sharma, S. Sreesanth — the core template remained constant. The 2001 Kolkata heist against Steve Waugh's Australia was not only about VVS Laxman and Rahul Dravid rewriting a follow-on; it was equally shaped by a teenage Harbhajan Singh, who picked 13 wickets, including a hat trick.

Between 1998 and 2008, the Kumble-Harbhajan partnership formed the backbone of India's home dominance, combining for 356 wickets in 34 home Tests that produced 14 wins. When the baton passed to R. Ashwin and Ravindra Jadeja, the numbers became even more emphatic. Over 49 home Tests, they claimed 515 wickets and powered 35 victories, forming the most destructive partnership Indian cricket has produced.

From 1990 to 2024 (before the home series against Bangladesh), India turned home advantage into a fortress, winning 87 of 144 Tests. But since Gautam Gambhir took over, India has won four and lost four home Tests — a sharp departure from the stability of his predecessors. Kumble (10 wins, one loss in 13), Ravi Shastri (13-1-17) and Dravid (8-2-11) all maintained India's long-term dominance on familiar soil.

India has now been outspun twice in quick

succession, first by New Zealand and then by South Africa. At Eden Gardens, a venue that usually offers a fair contest between bat and ball, the pitch broke up on Day 1, throwing up dust like a forgotten paperback pulled off a shelf. India mustered 282 runs across two innings and lost 12 of 18 wickets to spinners. Gambhir insisted India "got the wicket we wanted".

This overcorrection can be traced back to Delhi earlier in the season, where India's spinners struggled for long periods to bowl out West Indies on a flatter Kotla surface. In an era where World Test Championship points have made results paramount, stripping away the charm of a hard-fought draw, that inability to finish the job would have stayed with the team management.

The deeper concern, though, lies not with turn but with temperament. India's former No. 3s — Dravid (5598 runs, 13,207 balls in India), Laxman (3767 in 7710), Ajinkya Rahane (1644 in 3354), Cheteshwar Pujara (3839 in 7775) — were sculpted on challenging Ranji Trophy pitches, where technique is shaped over hours, not overs. Today's emerging batters — Sai Sudharsan (133 in 260 balls), Devdutt Padikkal (65 in 103), Washington Sundar (339 in 645), Karun Nair (374 in 506) — have barely faced the volume of balls that builds endurance.

Yet this generation is being thrust onto manufactured turners they were never trained for. The underlying arrogance of mistaking IPL adaptability for Test-match readiness has left India's batters caught between formats. Runs on 20-over surfaces do not translate into fourth-innings resilience.

At the Ranji Trophy level, we demand sporting surfaces from State associations and insist batters earn their runs. Yet at the highest level, India increasingly serves up undercooked wickets that reflect neither the domestic ladder nor the team's present skill set.

Which makes the question unavoidable: if your batters are no longer built for this, why insist on preparing exactly the pitches they are least prepared for?

Spin has always been India's ally. But overplaying the hand and misreading the moment is not strategy. It is a self-inflicted defeat.